

Nic Junius

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WORK EXPERIENCE

Narrative Designer; CCP Games (August 2024 - present)

EVE: Frontier is a survival MMO built using the proprietary Carbon engine

Responsibilities:

- Helped develop the tone and style of narrative presentation across the game.
- Developed a history generator to solidify narrative details at scale using data from a physics simulation as the foundation.
- Developed a new paradigm for working with AI behaviors within the existing behavior system.
- Iterated the AI behavior system to enable better authorability and control of NPCs as well as support dynamic in-game behavior.
- Developed multiple conlangs to create a stronger narrative foundations and open up new storytelling possibilities.

Expressive AI Engineer; UC Santa Cruz/Independent (September 2018 - present)

Puppitor is a game interface and character simulation library. Python and C# versions available.

Responsibilities:

- Developed theatrical model of character acting.
- Designed system architecture to implement the character acting model.
- Implemented system design in code and refined the library based on game design needs.
- Created an embedded domain specific language to define character actions and expressions.
- Developed debugging and testing tools to aid in authoring characters with the system.

Project Lead, Narrative Designer; UC Santa Cruz/Independent (September 2018 - present)

Tracks in Snow is an interactive drama visual novel developed using Python, Ren'Py, and Puppitor.

Responsibilities:

- Led the design of a novel interactive narrative experience rooted in character acting.
- Created feedback systems for human and AI controlled characters to support gameplay goals.
- Coordinated with artists and composers to create in game assets supporting the AI systems.
- Sole writer of the game's storyline and dialogue scripts.
- Built and maintained pipelines for rapidly adding narrative content to the rest of the game.

Expressive AI Engineer; UC Santa Cruz (January 2022 - July 2024)

The Mimic social navigation simulator is a robot and crowd simulation tool built in Unity using C#.

Responsibilities:

- Developed simulated character behavior.
- Implemented feature requests for AI systems.
- Built authoring pipelines and frameworks for character behavior and personalities.
- Tested, debugged, and profiled AI code.

Lead Writer; UC Santa Cruz (October 2017 - September 2020)

Academical is a choice-based interactive fiction training game for graduate students built in Twine.

Responsibilities:

- Developed style guidelines for other writers.

- Gave direction and feedback to drafts.
- Outlined narrative structure for scenarios.
- Edited for voice and consistency across scenarios.

Doctoral Researcher; UC Santa Cruz (September 2017 - August 2024)

Independently pursue research on expressive AI systems and narrative design.

Responsibilities:

- Published papers discussing AI system design and architecture.
- Published award winning papers discussing and critiquing narrative design.
- Advised on research-based interactive fiction projects.
- Advised on student game projects.

EDUCATION

PhD Computational Media | University of California, Santa Cruz (2021 - 2024)

MFA Digital Arts and New Media | University of California, Santa Cruz (2019 - 2021)

MS Computational Media | University of California, Santa Cruz (2017 - 2019)

BS Computer Science: Game Design | University of California, Santa Cruz (2012 - 2016)